

LITTLE SPROUT STORIES

Maya & Sophie Visit the Library

A story about feeling embarrassed — and learning every reader is different



The library was Maya’s favorite kind of quiet — the soft, rustly, page-turning kind. Sophie loved the library too. She loved the books, she loved the rug, she loved the enormous windows. The only trouble was the sitting still… which her legs had never quite agreed to.

Maya and Sophie visit the library.



Ms. Chen met them at the door with a smile that made her eyes crinkle at the corners. “Welcome, readers,” she said. “You’ve come on the best morning of the whole week — story time morning. Find a spot on the rug, and we will begin.”

Ms. Chen welcomes the readers.



“Before the first reader arrives,” Ms. Chen told them, “a librarian gets the library ready.” Click went the lights. Bump-bump-bump went the tall cart of returned books. She opened the book drop, where yesterday’s books waited in a sleepy pile, and woke up the computers one by one. “My first job every morning is making sure everything is ready for its readers.”

Ms. Chen gets the library ready.



Row after row of shelves stretched out like a little city, and every single book wore a label on its spine. “That label is the book’s address,” said Ms. Chen. “It tells us exactly where the book lives.” Then she tapped the catalogue computer. “And this clever machine can find any book in the whole library. Type a word — dinosaur, rocket, bear — and it whispers back the address.” Sophie’s eyes went round. “The books have houses!”

Every book has a home on the shelf.



Behind the desk, Ms. Chen was practicing. “’Not now,’ said the bear,” she read to an audience of stuffed animals, in a voice as deep as a cave — then, in a tiny squeak, “’But I am so very hungry!’” She laughed. “Librarians rehearse story time the way singers rehearse songs. The voices have to be ready before the readers are.”

Ms. Chen practices story time.



All morning long, the library welcomed the whole town. A grandfather settled in with the newspaper. A mother and a baby snuggled into the picture books. A student asked Ms. Chen for a book about volcanoes, and she found him three. “The library is like the town’s living room,” Ms. Chen said. “Everyone belongs here — and every book is free to borrow.”

The library is for everyone.



“Librarians are teachers, too,” said Ms. Chen, and she taught them the gentle art of holding a book: clean hands, pages turned slowly from the corner, and a bookmark to keep your place — never a folded-down page. “A book that is cared for,” she said, “can be read by a hundred children. Maybe a thousand.”

Ms. Chen teaches how to care for books.



Then story time began, and the rug filled with cross-legged readers. Ms. Chen’s bear voice rumbled and her mouse voice squeaked — but Sophie’s legs had ideas of their own. Wiggle. Wiggle-wiggle. A boy turned around. A girl turned around. Sophie’s cheeks flamed as hot as two little stoves, and she wished with all her heart that the floor would swallow her up.

Sophie feels embarrassed.

How does Sophie feel?

- ◯ Proud
- ◯ Embarrassed
- ◯ Bored



“I think I’m bad at library,” Sophie whispered, blinking hard. Maya took her hand. “Come with me,” she said, and she led Sophie to a corner where tall books stood in a colorful display — comics, with pictures as bright as fireworks. “Look,” said Maya. “Up here, you can read standing up.”

Maya helps Sophie.



Ms. Chen appeared beside them, smiling. “I heard somebody say they were bad at library,” she said, “and I do not believe it for one second. There is no one right way to enjoy a book. Some readers sit still as statues. Some readers wiggle. Both are real readers — and this library belongs to both.”

There is no one right way to read.

What did Sophie learn?

- ◯ There is one right way to read
- ◯ Readers can enjoy books differently
- ◯ Reading is boring



Sophie chose the brightest comic on the display and read it standing on her very tiptoes, turning every page slowly from the corner, just so. “You know my favorite part of this job?” Ms. Chen told Maya. “It isn’t the quiet. It’s watching every kind of reader find the book that fits them.” On her tiptoes, Sophie turned another page — and smiled like the sun coming out.

Sophie is a real reader.



At the desk, Ms. Chen scanned their books — beep, beep — and stamped the little card tucked inside. “Back next week?” she asked. “Back next week,” said Maya. “Back next week!” said Sophie, wiggling joyfully all the way to the door — which, they now knew, was a perfectly wonderful way to leave a library.

Maya and Sophie check out their books.



■ Library Explorer

Great reading!

For Grown-Ups

Feeling/skill: Embarrassment eases with self-acceptance and a friend’s help.

Ask your child: Is there a way you like to do something that is different from your friends?

Try this: Let your child choose how they sit and read tonight.

Words to grow on: rustly, enormous, catalogue, label, borrow, display, rehearse, embarrassed, tiptoes. Point at the tools as you name them — book drop, cart, spine label, catalogue computer, bookmark.

The bigger picture: Librarians do much more than read stories — they open and prepare the library every morning, keep thousands of books organized so any book can be found, rehearse and lead story times, teach readers how to find and care for books, help people answer questions and use computers, and keep the library a free, welcoming place where the whole town belongs.

Standards: RL.K.5, RL.K.6

The End — thanks for reading!